

Chapter 19: Enchanting

Ning Fuyi was stunned for a moment. Though she didn't understand, she could only do as told, nimbly flipping down and slowly walking to her side.

Though she couldn't see, she could determine direction by sound.

"Crouch down," Chu Qingqiu's voice sounded again.

Ning Fuyi also half-crouched accordingly, reaching out her hand. Before she could touch that warm body, her hand received a sharp slap, making her withdraw it in pain.

Just as she was about to complain that she was really difficult to serve, a soft sensation came from her wrist. Chu Qingqiu's fingertips, dampened with slightly cool sweat, grasped her wrist and guided it forward.

Slowly, she touched something cold. The surface was smooth, and when she felt carefully, she could sense the patterns on it. Ning Fuyi was puzzled, but following the object downward, she touched a patch of tender skin. The body in front of her suddenly trembled.

She reflexively withdrew her arm and hid her hand behind her back.

Strange, they were both women - what was she panicking about? The next instant, Ning Fuyi frowned in confusion.

"Are you injured?" she asked.

Chu Qingqiu hummed in acknowledgment. She seemed to lack the strength for more words, her voice somewhat ethereal, as if it would scatter with the wind: "This beast fang is poisonous. My immortal body is damaged and I can't extract it myself. You need to pull it out for me."

Ning Fuyi nodded. She reached out again, gripping the thumb-thick beast fang with both hands. Just a slight movement made her hear Chu Qingqiu's labored breathing.

"Why won't you let me see? This way I might hurt you," Ning Fuyi stopped her movement.

"Stop talking nonsense," Chu Qingqiu said.

Fine, Ning Fuyi thought, so she summoned immortal power to wrap around both hands, then pulled hard. With a squelching sound, as the beast fang was extracted, fresh blood also splattered out, spattering two drops on her face.

Chu Qingqiu suddenly closed her eyes, arching back in pain, but bit her teeth to suppress the sound in her throat. Blood seeped from the corner of her mouth before her breathing finally returned to normal, though it was too rapid, sounding like fragmented moans in Ning Fuyi's ears.

Ning Fuyi's movements paused. She quickly threw away the beast fang and spread her palm over the wound. A faint light appeared and dimmed, easing Chu Qingqiu's pain.

The young girl was blindfolded, showing only her high nose bridge and cherry-like lips. Two drops of blood stained her lotus-white skin, and strands of hair fell to one side as she tilted her head slightly to listen to Chu Qingqiu's movements.

Chu Qingqiu stared at such a face in a daze. After a long time, she finally looked away and spoke again.

"Bai Lin's blood can detoxify."

Ning Fuyi nodded. She gracefully stood up, conjuring a small bottle in her hand, following the scent of blood. The white tiger was also cooperative, actively nuzzling against Ning Fuyi.

After obtaining the blood, Ning Fuyi returned to Chu Qingqiu's side and handed her the bottle.

About half an incense stick's time later, the silk ribbon over Ning Fuyi's eyes loosened on its own, sliding down along her nose bridge.

A white-robed figure lay collapsed on the ground, her clothes stained with much blood. Chu Qingqiu was sitting under a rock, her long hair scattered, her handsome face completely bloodless - clearly severely injured.

The white clothes at her chest were stained with a patch of blood. The beast fang must have pierced there.

So what she had touched earlier was... Ning Fuyi suddenly felt her cheeks burning, but she quickly diverted her attention and didn't dwell on it.

Chu Qingqiu's clothes had also been torn. Now her outer robe was barely draped over her shoulders, as if just put on. Perhaps this was why she hadn't allowed her to look earlier, Ning Fuyi thought.

Truly worthy of Chu Qingqiu - even in great danger, she had to maintain her dignity. Ning Fuyi curled her lips.

However, for both Chu Qingqiu and Bai Lin to be injured to this extent showed how terrifying the attacking beast horde had been. Yet she herself was not only unharmed but had even recovered her immortal power, showing how well she had been protected.

Would Chu Qingqiu really protect her to this extent because of one word from Ning Changfeng? Once or twice, Ning Fuyi could still consider it as her truly keeping faith, but now she had actually risked her life to enter the ghost eye, and even when severely injured, she didn't forget to treat her. This could hardly be explained by a simple entrustment.

It seemed this lifetime's Chu Qingqiu harbored quite a few secrets. Ning Fuyi stared at Chu Qingqiu's reddened nose tip, contemplating silently in her heart.

She finally developed an interest in exploring the truth.

"Where there's one beast horde, there will be a second. There's too much blood scent here - it won't be long before more demon beasts are attracted. If we don't leave quickly, I'm afraid both of us will perish here today." Chu Qingqiu spoke while pressing against the rock, slowly standing up.

Ning Fuyi instinctively reached out to help, but Chu Qingqiu changed the position of her hand mid-air, silently avoiding her.

Ning Fuyi's hand awkwardly stopped in mid-air, so she hummed internally - if she didn't want to be touched, she didn't want to help anyway.

Seeing Chu Qingqiu stand up, the exhausted white tiger whimpered and transformed back into cat form, lying on the ground and immediately beginning to purr. Chu Qingqiu slightly opened her palm, and the white tiger turned into points of light, falling into a bead on her wrist.

That was a storage bead¹, a worldly treasure that could reportedly contain all things. Ning Fuyi had owned one in her previous life too.

"Let's go," Chu Qingqiu said.

For the rest of the journey, Chu Qingqiu never spoke, only slowly walking forward with her back to her. Instead, Ning Fuyi's words suddenly increased, talking about everything from celestial phenomena to geographical conditions. Though Chu Qingqiu never responded even once, she managed to keep the conversation going without dropping it.

"Divine Venerable Chu Ling, how much farther is it?" Ning Fuyi shifted Ping'an to her other shoulder.

"I don't know either," Chu Qingqiu finally spoke.

"My legs are about to break," Ning Fuyi said, quickly taking two steps to walk alongside Chu Qingqiu, but saw Chu Qingqiu actively move half a step to the other side.

So she absolutely wouldn't have contact with her? Ning Fuyi thought silently, then also seemingly casually moved toward her side.

"Is the Divine Venerable's injury serious?" Ning Fuyi made conversation.

"No matter," Chu Qingqiu said coldly, her steps shifting again.

"Divine Venerable..."

"Careful!" Before Ning Fuyi could finish speaking, she heard Chu Qingqiu's sharp shout, then her waist was wrapped by a white silk that dragged her entire body behind Chu Qingqiu.

Where Ning Fuyi had been standing, a deep pit the width of a person suddenly appeared. Dust flew through the air, making it impossible to open one's eyes.

"Fall back!" Before Ning Fuyi could say anything, Chu Qingqiu spoke again. As her palm turned, a white jade flute with an even, lustrous body appeared in her palm. Raising her hand, the jade flute transformed into a slender staff, slowly emitting white light.

This was Chu Qingqiu's magical artifact, White Bone. Ning Fuyi obediently retreated repeatedly until her back was pressed tightly against the rock wall before stopping.

When she looked up again, her heart suddenly stirred. She saw dust scattering everywhere, Chu Qingqiu's figure exposed in the rolling smoke, her dark hair swaying, her long robes fluttering like a white eagle spreading its tail feathers - beautiful enough to be breathtaking.

Immortal power spread magnificently, showing no trace of her previous frail appearance.

At the same time, earth-shaking beast roars rang out. Ning Fuyi had never heard such terrifying sounds - just one cry made people dizzy and disoriented, as if their hearts were being fiercely squeezed. Her knees immediately went weak, and she nearly slid down the rock wall.

She quickly circulated her energy to protect her heart meridian before barely managing to straighten her waist and witness that shocking scene.

In front of Chu Qingqiu stood a demon beast - or perhaps the words "demon beast" could hardly describe its terror. If there truly were evil gods in this world, they would be no worse than this. The pointed horns on its head were like two high peaks, its fur was like spikes, with some severed limbs hanging from them, emanating stinking turbid qi.

Sharp teeth protruded beyond its lips, revealing blood-red flesh. When it opened its mouth and roared angrily, the entire valley bottom was filled with flying sand and rolling stones.

After it appeared, all demon beast auras in the vicinity completely disappeared. No demon beast within a hundred li dared approach, showing how terrifying this demon beast was - definitely not something that could be described by simple terms like low-level, mid-level, or high-level.

And Chu Qingqiu stood opposite it, looking like a mantis trying to stop a chariot², tiny as an ant.

At this moment, even Ning Fuyi's heart tightened. Just as she was about to remind Chu Qingqiu that retreat was the better option, the demon beast suddenly turned its head, its two blood-red eyes fixed deadly on her.

Almost simultaneously, dozens of flying spikes shot out from somewhere, heading straight for Ning Fuyi's face, seemingly determined to kill with one strike. Ning Fuyi's eyes widened as she flipped to dodge, but Chu Qingqiu's white jade staff was faster than her. In the blink of an eye, it appeared in front of her, spinning into a white shield that blocked those flying spikes.

The flying spikes clattered to the ground. Ning Fuyi glanced with her peripheral vision - each spike was thicker and longer than an arrow. She clenched her fists in belated fear.

With a whoosh, White Bone flew back to Chu Qingqiu's palm, and Chu Qingqiu's figure appeared accordingly, standing straight in front of Ning Fuyi.

Her blood-scented dark hair brushed past Ning Fuyi's nose tip, no longer carrying its usual crisp fragrance, yet it made Ning Fuyi dazed for a moment.

"What are you standing there for? Go quickly!" Chu Qingqiu didn't linger. She pushed Ning Fuyi hard, then her form became a shadow as she faced the demon beast. For a time, murderous aura intertwined with dust, completely obscuring the scene in mid-air, with only snow-white flowing light occasionally piercing through the dust, illuminating the valley bottom brilliantly.

In those days of being bullied and humiliated, struggling alone in the mud, Ning Fuyi had once hoped that someone would appear to protect her like this.

But there was no one - from beginning to end, there was only herself.

Ning Fuyi's gaze gradually hardened. She raised her sleeve to cover her nose, stepping back and leaving from the side.

However, after running just two steps, movement came from behind again. Turbid qi that had almost become solid appeared behind her in an instant, coolness invading her entire body. Ning Fuyi abruptly turned back - the blinding white light nearly made her shed tears.

Chu Qingqiu appeared in front of her again. Her face visibly lost all color, and Ning Fuyi's sharp eyes noticed that the wound on her chest that had already scabbed over had torn open again, fresh blood flowing like a clear spring.

Why exactly? Ning Fuyi shut her eyes tightly. She knew how much she hated Chu Qingqiu, but when she kept protecting her from disasters like this, risking her life repeatedly, such hatred seemed insignificant for that moment.

The turbid qi impacted the two of them. Chu Qingqiu's white jade staff expanded like a giant pillar, stabbing into the ground and barely blocking part of it. However, her injuries were truly too severe, and with the valley bottom's murderous aura eroding her, her immortal power was really difficult to sustain.

So Ning Fuyi watched helplessly as a stream of fresh blood flowed from Chu Qingqiu's mouth, and then that slender figure that had been standing firm finally loosened, collapsed by the turbid qi, falling backward with her.

Ping'an on her shoulder let out a wail and was thrown to the corner.

Ning Fuyi thought this was bad, quickly wrapping her left hand around her waist and surging immortal power from her right hand to cushion behind them, preventing herself from falling into the mud. But the demon beast obviously didn't intend to let them go, roaring toward the sky again. Overwhelming turbid qi gathered in mid-air into a palm shape, slapping down heavily like a giant.

Forget it, if she must die, she wouldn't die as a coward. Ning Fuyi cursed angrily, then while silently reciting demonic cultivation techniques, she circled out from behind Chu Qingqiu, supporting her with one hand while opening the five fingers of her other hand toward the turbid qi.

In an instant, the wind seemed to stop, the surroundings became silent, with only thunderous heartbeats rumbling to remind her she was still alive.

Then, familiar warmth surged from her heart, and an enchanting, gorgeous pink light burst from her palm, like the extremely rare sunset glow of spring days, continuously covering the sky full of black haze.

"What the hell," Ning Fuyi blurted out.

Author's Note: Ning Fuyi: On this day of family reunion and joyous celebration, this king will treat it as setting off fireworks for you all. Wishing everyone a happy Year of the Rabbit.

Chu Qingqiu: My wife is right.

¹ Storage bead (一念珠) - A magical storage device that can contain vast amounts of items in a small space, similar to a spatial ring.

² Mantis trying to stop a chariot (螳臂当车) - A Chinese idiom meaning to attempt something that is impossible or to overestimate one's capabilities.